

UKRAINE, MOLDOVA, AND THE CAUCASIAN REPUBLICS

THE GRASSY STEPPE LOWLANDS of Ukraine and Moldova lie in the east of Europe. Farther east, the three mountainous Caucasian Republics of Georgia, Armenia, and Azerbaijan lie between the Black Sea and the Caspian Sea, cradled by the Caucasus Mountains. From the 17th century on, the Russian Empire dominated this region, and in the 20th century it became part of the USSR, regaining independence only in the 1990s. Fertile farmland and a wealth of natural resources have made this area one of the richest parts of the former USSR. The region's mountains give it protection from the extreme cold of the Russian winters, and this may help encourage a future tourist industry, particularly along the Black Sea coast.



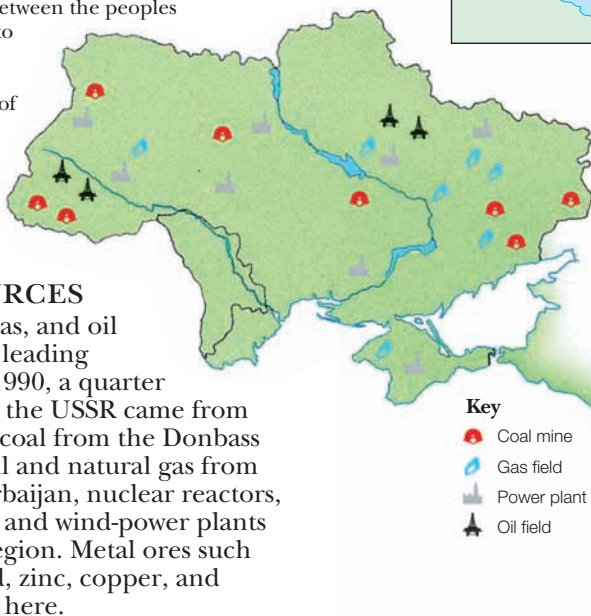
These children at a wedding in Azerbaijan are from different ethnic groups.

PEOPLES

The people of Ukraine and Moldova are mostly European, while more than 50 different ethnic groups exist in the Caucasian Republics. The USSR tried to wipe out differences between the peoples of its empire by forcing them to use the Russian language and by suppressing local culture. However, many of the people of this region have a proud and ancient history and have struggled to hold on to their own languages and culture.

NATURAL RESOURCES

Large deposits of coal, gas, and oil have made this region a leading producer of energy. In 1990, a quarter of all the energy used in the USSR came from this area. In addition to coal from the Donbass Basin in Ukraine, and oil and natural gas from the Caspian Sea off Azerbaijan, nuclear reactors, hydroelectric programs, and wind-power plants have been built in the region. Metal ores such as iron, manganese, lead, zinc, copper, and uranium are also mined here.



Key

- Coal mine
- Gas field
- Power plant
- Oil field



Azerbaijan's huge oil reserves are now starting to be exploited.